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4 Practice Secrets

I Learned Studying With One of the World's Greatest Pianists

That Nobody Teaches in Regular Piano Lessons

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Who I Learned These Secrets From

When I was accepted to study at the Conservatorium Maastricht, I found myself in the studio of Igor Roma — a pianist who had won First Prize at the International Franz Liszt Piano Competition in Utrecht, performed at the Concertgebouw in Amsterdam and the Lincoln Center in New York, and toured with some of the greatest orchestras in the world.

Igor Roma is not famous in the way pop stars are famous. He is famous in the way that matters in the world of concert pianism — respected by peers, sought after by conservatories, and known for producing musicians who actually sound like musicians.

What I observed in his studio completely changed how I understood the piano. The way he thought about practice, sound, and musical intention was nothing like anything I had been taught before.

In this guide, I am sharing four of the core principles I took from that experience — the ones that I now teach every single student in my Academy, from complete beginners to advanced players. They are simple. They are counterintuitive. And they work.

***"Most pianists practice to get through the piece.
Professionals practice to understand it. These are two
completely different things."***

— Juri Nardelli

1 SECRET Stop Wasting Energy

The Louder You Play, the Worse You Sound

One of the first things I noticed watching Igor Roma work with students was this: the moment someone started playing too hard, he would stop them immediately. Not because of the volume — because of the waste.

Most pianists unconsciously use ten times the physical energy required to produce a sound. They press into the keys. They tense their arms. They force the music. The result is not more sound — it is worse sound. Harder, flatter, less musical.

The professional approach is the opposite. You learn to produce the maximum musical result with the minimum physical effort. This means:

- Playing softer than feels natural — especially in passages you find difficult
- Releasing tension between every note rather than gripping through the phrase
- Letting the weight of your arm do the work, not the pressure of your fingers
- Practicing the passage pianissimo first — if you cannot control it softly, you cannot control it at all

The most controlled, musical playing always comes from the pianist who uses the least force — not the most.

Try this today: take the passage that frustrates you most. Play it at half the volume you normally use, at half the speed. Notice how much easier it becomes to hear the individual notes, control the phrasing, and feel the musical shape. That feeling is the beginning of real piano playing.

2 SECRET Memorize the Left Hand First

The Foundation Most Pianists Ignore

Ask any amateur pianist which hand they focus on and they will tell you: the right hand. The melody. The part everyone hears. This is completely understandable — and it is one of the main reasons most pianists struggle.

Concert pianists think the opposite way. The left hand is the foundation. It carries the harmony, the rhythm, the bass line, the underlying pulse of the entire piece. If the left hand is uncertain, the right hand will always be uncertain too — because it has nothing stable to rest on.

The method is simple but transformative:

- Learn the left hand first — completely, independently, from memory
- Do not touch the right hand until the left hand runs automatically
- Practice the left hand until it feels easier than breathing
- Only then add the right hand — and notice how naturally it sits on top

The right hand sings. The left hand breathes. You cannot sing if you cannot breathe.

When the left hand is truly memorized — not just learned, but automatic — something remarkable happens. You stop thinking about the notes and start thinking about the music. That shift is everything.

3 SECRET Reverse Practice

Work Backwards From the Problem

Every pianist has that one bar. The one that falls apart every single time. The one that makes you dread reaching it in a run-through. Most pianists deal with it the same way: they play it again and again, hoping repetition will eventually fix it. It never does.

The professional solution is counterintuitive: you practice backwards. Instead of approaching the problem bar from the beginning of the phrase, you start at the problem bar itself — and you work backwards from there.

Here is how it works in practice:

- Identify the bar that consistently fails — this is your target
- Practice that bar alone, slowly, until it is solid
- Add the bar immediately before it — practice those two together
- Add one more bar before — practice those three together
- Continue backwards until you reach a point of confidence
- Now run the whole section — you will arrive at the problem bar already in motion

The problem is never just the bar itself. It is always the approach to the bar.

By practicing backwards, you train yourself to arrive at the difficult passage already confident, already in the right physical position, already in the right musical frame of mind. The bar stops being a wall and becomes just another moment in the music.

4 Slow Motion Practice

Find the Natural Flow Inside the Music

Slow practice is the most misunderstood concept in piano learning. Most students know they should practice slowly. Almost none of them understand why — which means they do it wrong, and it does not work.

Slow practice is not about being careful. It is not about avoiding mistakes. It is about finding the natural physical flow inside the music — the way your hand wants to move, the weight that wants to transfer, the breath inside each phrase.

When you play slowly enough, you begin to notice things that are completely invisible at full speed:

- Where your hand is tensing unnecessarily between notes
- Where the natural peak of the phrase actually falls — not where you assumed it was
- Where you are rushing instinctively because the passage feels hard
- Where the musical intention changes — and your fingers need to change with it
- Where the sound you are producing does not match the sound you are imagining

If you cannot play it beautifully at half speed, you cannot play it beautifully at full speed. You are only hiding the problems.

The rule is simple: slow down until you can hear every note as a musical choice, not just a physical action. When that happens — when every note has intention — gradually increase the tempo. You will find that the passage at full speed carries the same musical intelligence. That is what professional playing sounds like.

These 4 Secrets Are Just the Beginning

The four principles in this guide are not abstract concepts. They are the foundation of how I work with every student in my Academy — applied to real pieces, real technique, and real musical goals.

In private mentorship sessions, we take these principles and apply them directly to your repertoire — whether you are playing your first real piece or working towards Chopin, Beethoven, or Rachmaninov. The difference between reading about these secrets and working through them with a concert pianist is the difference between knowing and doing.

The Academy might be right for you if:

- ✓ You are an adult who wants to start piano properly — from the very beginning, the right way
- ✓ You have been playing for years but feel stuck and don't sound how you want
- ✓ You want to play serious repertoire — Chopin, Beethoven, Rachmaninov — with real guidance
- ✓ You want to work online, on your schedule, with a concert-level pianist
- ✓ You are serious about your playing and ready to practice with intention

The first step is a free 20-minute discovery call. No pressure — just a conversation about where you are and where you want to go.

■ jurinardelli.com/academy

Thank you for reading. I hope these four secrets change how you sit at the piano.

— *Juri*

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